Igloo Coup

By Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota

(Marcie hands children candy canes as they head to Santa's castle.)

MARCIE: Now, now, keep that candy cane in your mouth. Don't poke your brother in the eye with that. All sticky. I'm a candy cane too and we don't like to be put in people's eyes. We like to be hung on a tree or eaten. Yum, yum. *(To Denise.)* OK, that sounded wrong. *(To Denise, loudly so children can hear.}* Hello, Snowflake! Look, it's our Snowflake Helper who's come to visit us in Candy Land.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: Denise has been dying to play the part of the Snow Princess at Northgate Mall's Christmas display since she was a child. This year, she convinced her roommate and fellow actress, Marcie, to go with her to the audition.

ACTRESS 2: Marcie was thrilled to be cast as a Candy Cane. Unfortunately, Denise was extremely unhappy to get the part of a Snowflake Helper, understudy to the Princess. The Snow Princess role went to a grossly ill-prepared girl who flirted mercilessly with the casting director.

ACTRESS 1: The Snow Princess makes out with the Toy Soldier in public, she burps and slouches, and treats the Snowflake Helpers like scum.

ACTRESS 2: Something has to be done! Christmas must be saved! Actresses everywhere unite!

TOGETHER: Igloo Coup by Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota.

DENISE: *(To another child.)* Hey, don't be naughty. Someone's got a list, and he's going to cross you off. So watch your hands. Chop, chop.

MARCIE: *(To Denise.)* Hey. What's with Ms. Snowflake? She sounds a little *(Makes brrr sound.)* coldish today, doesn't she? It's always coldish *(Making brrr*

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sound again.} in the North Pole. Coooollld. Brrr!

DENISE: *(To Marcie.)* I'm sorry. I'm just in a bad mood.

MARCIE: I know. I know. Snow Princess again? What's going on?

DENISE: She's got no respect for the part, Marcie. I have to see it day in and day out.

MARCIE: I know, I know. But we just gotta realize sometimes it's not about the talent, it's about who you know.

DENISE: I know. Her Santa connection got her right in. And that's all she needed.

MARCIE: So what's she up to this time?

DENISE: She was making out with a Toy Soldier in the hallway.

MARCIE: No way! You're kidding!? In costume? Did anyone see her?

DENISE: No, because luckily I was there to avert the children's eyes. I was turning kids toward Willy Wonka like crazy.

MARCIE: Oh, thank God, but he's a weirdo, huh? He told me he had channeled the great Gene Wilder to play the part. And he seemed thoroughly confused. And our Varuka is a little *(Winds up hand to express crazy.}* woo-hoo typecast.

DENISE: Oh, I know. Well, the whole Candy Land section was poorly directed and cast.

MARCIE: *(Offended.)* Hey! I'm part of Candy Land.

DENISE: Oh God, I didn't mean you. I've never seen anybody so committed.

MARCIE: Really? I was thinking my red-and-white thing was off. I wasn't feeling very stripy, you know? I'm just so one color typically. Today I thought I'd try not working so hard at being striped. No indicating. Is it working?

DENISE: Like a charm. I see you and stripes vibrate but very subtly. Not pushing at all. Really, I'm just. . . well, I'm so proud to be your fellow actor. I can see that our first semester of classes has already paid off. You seem very enthusiastic *and* calming. Very red-and-white. Just like a candy cane should be.

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MARCIE: Oh God. Really? I thought I was doing OK 'cause some kid licked my face this morning. But what about the sugary thing? Do I seem sugary enough?

DENISE: Let me see? Can you show me what you're doing with that? *(Marcie puts her arms straight down in candy cane form but she smiles with her whole face, trying to look super sweet.)*

DENISE: Oh, wow, wow, that is great. But don't push. *(Marcie smiles but more gently this time, lifting her eyebrow suggestively.)* Incredible, but don't bend from the waist. It makes you look like a disfigured candy cane. And that's a little disturbing.

MARCIE: So tell me, what's going down at the igloo?

DENISE: *(Shakes her head.)* It's a nightmare. The Princess thinks that just because we're Snowflake Helpers that we're her personal Flakes. She told me to get her a Diet Coke.

MARCIE: Who died and made her Prin-well, you know what I mean.

DENISE: Exactly. And it's totally wrong for the character. A Snow Princess would not drink a Diet Coke obviously. It's not classic Christmas. Hot cocoa would be an apropos choice.

MARCIE: Or hot cider?

DENISE: Yeah, yeah! *(Marcie nods.}* Well, no, too Halloween. See? Because we care, we bother to think the choices through. She doesn't care. She sweats even though she lives in an igloo. She slouches and hunches down in her throne drinking her Diet Coke, which she doesn't even hide. The kids walk in. Me, Marion, and Mike are very serious about being as unique as possible even though our costumes are very similar. Marion is a very light flake. George is very watery. And I'm a very big flake.

MARCIE: Wow. That's so great that you're differentiating.

DENISE: Mike thinks I've got big flake down pat. Anyway, we all bow down to her and

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call her "Your Majesty." We talk about her glistening ice shoes and her lovely gown and show the children the icicle water fountain. We're very proper. So what does she do? She asked some kid where she could buy a good CD burner, and then proceeded to light a cigarette and blow smoke up the igloo chimney. See what I'm dealing with. She said it made the chimney look realistic. I was horrified. I tried to call Jerry so that he could see what damage she was doing. So he could fire her. But she always makes nice-nice and hides her cigarettes and gum and pops and pretends to be a good Snow Princess when he's around. But I lost it this afternoon when I saw her with the Toy Soldier. It took me right over the edge. I didn't know if I could work with this false Princess anymore.

MARCIE: I don't blame you. I mean, a Princess should not be slinking around with the Toy Soldier. I mean, the Baby Doll and Soldier maybe, but

DENISE: I just wanted to quit!

MARCIE: *(Gasps.)* No. Don't do that! You know you need the experience. Besides, we've got that November phone bill and the 30 percent holiday discount. And more importantly, when they see how good you are, you could definitely be the Princess next year.

DENISE: I know, that's what got me thinking. *(Quietly, whispering.)* And then I got this other thought.

MARCIE: *(Quietly.)* What other thought?

DENISE: We could overthrow her. A coup, a coup.

MARCIE: Bless you.

DENISE: No! A coup! Nobody likes her over there in the igloo. The Jackin-the-Box is the only one. The flakes are all behind me. Even Baby Doll and the Sugar Plum want her out. And all of them know I was gypped out of the part. We get her fired by presenting some incriminating evidence. Smudge the Snow

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Princess's white reputation.

MARCIE: Oh gosh. So how you gonna do that?

DENISE: Well, you know how Baby Doll smokes, right? But she's real cool about it. She's trying to quit and wouldn't dare do it during a performance. Well, she's agreed to lure the Princess into the fire escape door and get her smoking in full costume, which is strictly against the rules. Now mind you, we have to wait to get the signal that Baby Doll's cigarette is out, and that's where you come in.

MARCIE: Oh no! I can't do anything cooish!

DENISE: It's not coup-ish. All you're doing is calling Jerry and showing him how the fire escape door was left open.

MARCIE: I don't know, Denise. I need this opportunity. Besides, I don't think Candy Canes are really talkative. I mean, maybe I should be mute.

DENISE: Well, fine, if you want to go that way, then just point then.

MARCIE: But I'm probably technically not supposed to have hands either. I've been shoddy with my homework. Besides, I just can't do this. They might suspect me.

DENISE: What are you talking about? No one's going to think you did anything. It's all very innocent.

MARCIE: I don't know. My station is very close to Santa Claus. If he catches word of this attack on his friend, the Snow Princess, you know I'm gonna go down.

DENISE: Jeez, Marcie, I thought we were in this together. You're gonna let this Diet Coke-drinking, heavy-smoking witch represent the Snow Princess in the upcoming Northgate Mall parade? You're going to let the sleaze suck face with Toy Soldiers in front of the innocent tots as they wave to Santa?

MARCIE: Well, well, I know, but. . . Why don't you do it?

DENISE: Don't you see? If I do it, it'll look obvious. I'm the understudy. It'll look

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like I set her up.

MARCIE: No, it won't. *(Beat.)* Well, didn't you?

DENISE: Yes, that's why I don't want it to look like it!

MARCIE: You don't understand. I need this part, Denise. You've shown Jerry your range, as the Pilgrim Lady and the Fourth of July Hat. This is the first part I've landed. I just don't want to screw it up.

DENISE: Honey, you won't. I promise. The reason I am so frustrated and distraught is *because* of my experience. I've been a Candy Cane. I've been the Pilgrim. I've been a Pumpkin. I know what it takes to be a good Snow Princess, and that bimbo just stole the part from under me. Because she knew the big, fat red guy. Sure, if she cared about the performance, about the truth of the role, like you and I care, I wouldn't mind. I'd applaud and bow to her and give her my Snowflake offerings, but she doesn't. She spits in my face! She laughs at me and even mocked me. She said I'm a flake ball. Not a snow ball. That wouldn't offend, but a flake ball. To her all I am is a Flake! She told me! And even though I am, I knew what she meant. Do you see how that hurts? Do you see how that destroys my confidence?

MARCIE: Sure. But what about the other Flakes? Can't they help?

DENISE: There are only three of us. Someone would notice if we all left our station. With the Candy Canes there are plenty of you. Nobody will even notice. Please, please, when she mocks me, don't you see? She mocks all of us who care.

MARCIE: Ohhh. I don't know. It's so hard. Sometimes I think this business is so shallow and empty. I mean, I wonder if we're not all fighting for something ridiculous. I mean, vying for the big part. And what is the big part really, but some fancy costume in a made-up world of department sales. I know it sounds cynical, but what is more cynical than our commercialization and mass

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marketing of complicated historical and religious events like Christmas that we simplify and destroy in order to sell sofas and wall-to-wall carpeting?

DENISE: Yeah, but you get to be in a parade. Did I mention that she said all the Candy Canes sucked?

MARCIE: *(Shocked.)* What! But she doesn't even watch us. What did she mean by that?

DENISE: She said none of you had any acting ability at all. You all sucked!

MARCIE: *(Face drops.)* Maybe she could argue with our interpretation, but that little

DENISE: And she makes ten dollars an hour to our seven fifty!

MARCIE: Oh my-this is outrageous!

DENISE: So you'll do it?

MARCIE: I will. Proudly. I'm going out on a limb. I'm thinking a Candy Cane could point, as long as it does it with its whole Candy Cane self.

DENISE: Wow. Now, that I've seen you enraged like this, I see it in you. You're gonna be a great actress, Marcie. You could play the Snow Princess someday too.

MARCIE: And then Blanche DuBois, Lady Macbeth!

DENISE: Let's not jump ahead, but certainly Dainty Duck for Easter or one of the Cratchet's daughters next Christmas.

MARCIE: *(Cringes as a kid licks her.)* Ahh! Some kid just licked my knee.

DENISE: See? See. See! You *are* the Candy Cane! You have power and subtlety. The essence of red-and-white.

MARCIE: OK, Snowflake, my nonexistent Candy Cane feet are gonna kick some Princess butt.

DENISE: Bravo! Get your sugar content up! The battle begins!

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